

FORGE — FDE Academy · D3 · 25-Jun-2026



FDE Role & Identity · Product Mindset · Handling Ambiguity



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Origin — Engineering Moved to the Edge

From building for everyone to solving for someone



FDE emerged when product teams realized that complex customer problems cannot be solved from a distance.



GENERIC PRODUCT

Designed for scale.
Built for broad use.



FDE AT THE INTERSECTION

Embedded with customers.
Translating reality into
product decisions.



NON-GENERIC CUSTOMER REALITY

Unique constraints.
Local context. High stakes.



**FDE is not
consulting
plus coding.
It is field
intelligence
converted into
software
judgment.**



The FDE was born where generic product meets non-generic reality.

Doctrine — The Customer Site is the Compiler

From building for everyone to solving for someone



The FDE doctrine is simple: go where the problem lives, understand the real workflow, build the smallest useful system, and harden what survives use.

1

Go where the problem lives



2

Understand the real workflow



3

Build the smallest useful system



4

Harden what survives use



The FDE does not just gather requirements. The FDE debugs the customer's operating model.



FDEs turn ambiguity into executable reality.

Why Now – AI Increased the Deployment Gap



AI made prototypes easy, but production trust harder.



FDE



1

Prompt to
workflow



2

Demo to
adoption



3

Output to
decision



4

Capability to
control



5

Pilot to
ownership



The bottleneck
is no longer
model access.
It is enterprise
translation.



In the AI era, the FDE is the deployment layer between intelligence and institutional change.

Product Mindset — Outcomes Over Outputs



FDEs do not celebrate artefacts. They look for changed operating behavior.



OUTPUT



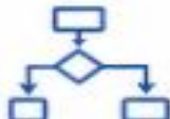
model



agent



dashboard



workflow

VS.



OUTCOME



faster
decision



lower
risk



fewer
escalations



better
handover



stronger
trust



Niche insight: The real product is not the software.
It is the new operating capability created inside the customer environment.

Problem-Fit Before Product-Fit



Product-fit asks:
“Can our tool
solve this?”

vs.

Problem-fit asks:
“Is this real, valuable,
frequent, owned, measurable,
and safe to solve?”



A problem is FDE-worthy only when it has:



pain
intensity



decision
frequency



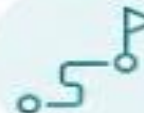
workflow
owner



usable
data



economic
value



adoption
path



risk
boundary



Niche insight: The first prototype should test the problem, not the product.

The FDE Product Test

Three tests to ensure the solution is real, adopted, and sustainable.



1. Value Test: What business condition improves?

Define the specific, measurable business condition that will be better after deployment.



2. Behavior Test: Who will work differently?

Identify the roles and behaviors that must change for value to be realized.



REAL.
ADOPTED.
SUSTAINABLE.



3. Ownership Test: Who runs it after the demo?

Name the owner, the operating model, and the funding for ongoing success.



If these are
unclear, the
build is theatre.



Niche insight: Do not just build what was requested.
Reshape the system until value can survive deployment.

Discovery → Framing



Insight: FDEs do not collect requirements.
They convert messy reality into a decision-ready problem.



DISCOVERY

Find the truth: users, workflows, data, constraints, risks



USERS



WORKFLOWS



DATA



CONSTRAINTS



RISKS



FRAMING

Turn truth into scope, assumptions, metrics, decision rules



SCOPE



ASSUMPTIONS



METRICS



DECISION RULES



Niche takeaway: The first FDE deliverable is not a solution.
It is clarity that can survive stakeholder conflict.

Prototype → Harden



Insight: The prototype is a learning instrument, not a product.



Niche takeaway: FDEs do not harden everything. They harden only what survives contact with real users.

Handover

Where FDE Value Becomes Enterprise Value



Insight: A solution is not deployed until someone else can own it.





Build the scaffold every later session stands on.

pytest green · contract tested · provider swappable · committed for 26-Jun